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Beyond Control

I stepped onto the training floor and found Danni and Emma turning around each other in the cage, looking for openings. Hands out and loose. Not a spar. Some sort of grappling lesson, maybe?

Sure enough, Emma picked her moment and launched forward, hooking her left hand behind Danni's neck in what's known as the single collar tie. An attempt to get control of her opponent and limit her movement. But Danni was big and strong and fast. She fought against the move while quickly bringing her arm up inside Emma's and going for a tie of her own. Emma saw it, released Danni's neck, then brought her arm back inside and tried to re-secure the grapple. Then Danni brought her arm back inside. Then Emma. Then Danni. Pummeling for position, they call it. The fighter with her arm inside will have better control. The trick was to latch it in and get that control before your opponent can reverse the arm positions. They twisted and squirmed, poking at each other with their free hands. Each giving the other something else to think about it.

Then Emma changed tactics. Danni got her arm inside, but Emma didn't try to reverse it. Instead, her free hand came up under Danni's elbow. I knew what she was doing. So did Danni. She was trying to grapple the arm. To use it as a lever. Clever, but not fast enough. Danni snatched the arm out while simultaneously shoving the smaller fighter away with her other hand.

They both stood upright and paused the action. Emma was disappointed. Clearly, this was not her first try, and she thought she had it this time. Danni started talking and gesturing. Her movements positive and reassuring. The mentor at work. Then she crouched into her stance and waved Emma forward with her hands.

C'mon. Try again.

Emma matched the crouch and they started to circle again. The sequence repeated itself. Grappling and twisting and pummeling. Unfortunately for Emma, it ended the same way, too.

Danni stayed in her crouch and waved some more.

Again, again!

Twice more they danced. Still no joy for Emma. But the fifth go-round brought results.

Her move to attack the arm was cleaner and more explosive. She got hold and pulled. Danni lurched forward, forced into a step by Emma's yanking. Emma locked the elbow and pushed, treating the arm like a rigid tree branch. The quick pull-push threw Danni off-balance. Emma released the elbow but kept the collar as she crouched low and picked Danni's ankle off the mat. Already off-balance and now one-footed, Danni was helpless as Emma dumped her right on her butt.

Danni was quick. Knowing what was coming, she kicked up immediately and tried to catch the attacking Emma in her guard. Emma was quicker, getting past Danni's legs and securing the mount. Game over. In a

real fight, Danni would probably be doomed. The punches would rain down long before she could defend herself, and - even if she somehow stayed conscious long enough to get her arms up - Emma would have an almost uncountable number of other options to get the finish. The smirk appeared as the smart-mouthed Emma pointed that out, and Danni wrenched an arm loose and took a playful swipe at her in response.

They laughed as they both rolled up to sitting, and Emma said something clearly disrespectful. *Cheeky*, I believe she'd call it. Danni did not take kindly to it, and took another swipe. Emma shoved her back. The laughter continued.

Just one of the girls.

They both looked up as I approached.

"Having fun ladies?"

Danni gestured at Emma.

"Punk here picks me once, now she thinks she's hot shit."

"Took you right down, big girl," Emma cooed. "No stopping me now."

"Wanna bet?"

I shook my head.

Fighters.

This kind of *Kiss my ass!-No, you kiss MY ass!* thing made no sense here. Danni had been teaching Emma to get the pick. She had WANTED it.

But that's the way it is with fighters. Everything's a competition, even when it isn't. And this banter could go on forever if I let it.

"Alright, alright," I waved at them. "I was just making conversation. I don't really care that much."

There was another brief period of lighthearted pushing and shoving before they settled back down.

Then, out of the blue, Danni looked at me and said, "I feel like skipping tonight."

I immediately hit Emma with a hard look.

"Hey! Woah!" she protested. "Not my fault! You saw... I was taking it easy on her!"

Danni looked another *Kiss my ass* her way, then turned back to me.

"We leave for the tournament in two days," she said. "I could use the rest."

"That's funny," I said. "I was just thinking we leave for the tournament in two days, so now is not the time to be slacking."

She raised an eyebrow at me.

"You know I don't need your permission, right? I'm doing it this way to be nice."

"You know you work for me, right? You're supposed to do what I say."

We traded hard but knowing looks for a little while. Both of us knew this wasn't a real argument. An hour or so of training wasn't going to make a difference, either way. But now that we'd given each other a hard time over it, we had an unspoken obligation to stand our ground for a sufficient period of time.

Fighters.

"I'd rather spend the night, just the two of us relaxing a little," she said.

She was pushing my buttons now. You know that feeling I've been getting? It's still growing, and I'm starting to get the impression Danni not only knows it, but is nurturing it. Before she said we needed to go on dates. Now she seems to prefer to stay in.

Just the two of us.

And I liked it.

Meanwhile, Emma was quick to jump on the opportunity she'd been given.

"See?" she interjected. "Not my fault."

I looked at her sideways, then back to Danni.

"I suppose this relaxing is also going to include dinner," I said.

She shrugged, and I could already see the bullshit coming.

"We can just order something."

"Oh, sure," I snorted. "Let's eat some crap just before the big tournament. We should run that by Steph. That would be fun."

Another shrug.

"You feel like cooking, go ahead," she said as she started to walk away.

"You got something in mind, or am I supposed to guess?"

"You make it, I'll eat it," she called over her shoulder.

I've noticed she says that a lot. Enough that I've found myself wondering just how much a personal chef gets paid.

I shook my head, then turned to find Emma giving me the smirk.

"What?"

"You guys are weird."

"No weirder than the two of you arguing over who won a training session."

"I guess," she mused. "Seems weirder, though."

I rolled my eyes and changed the subject.

"How's it going?" I asked with a nod toward the cage.

No need to explain. Danni's readiness was my obsession, and everybody knew it.

And some of them were getting a little tired of it.

"Oh, would you stop?" Emma said. "She's fine. She's BEEN fine. Never been finer."

I flushed a little. She was right, and I knew it. But I couldn't help myself. Any chance I got, I asked. Just to be sure.

"And you?" I asked.

Her mood quickly turned serious, which told me more than what she said.

"I feel good," she said. "I feel like I've patched some of the holes in my game."

But I can't be sure it's enough, her tone added.

"I think you're ready," I said.

"And how would you know?"

"I've been watching," I said. "I see how hard you've been working."

"Yeah," she sighed. "I guess."

"Who needs to *just stop* now?" I said. "You've done all you can."

"Yeah, but..."

"No 'buts.' You've worked hard. You should be proud of that. And you've always been one of the best. Now, you're even better. Have a little faith in yourself."

Neither of us said anything for a while. She gazed off into the distance. Thinking. Wanting to accept that what I'd said, but struggling with it.

I waited. There was no point in forcing it. If she wanted to talk some more, she would.

She changed the subject instead.

"What about the rookies?" she asked.

"What about them? You're more in touch with where they're at than I am."

Things around here had been changing pretty fast. One minute, the rookies are looking to make sure I'll be around to help them. Next thing you know, they drop me like a hot potato to go play with their famous new friends. Just yesterday, I'd found Dove in the cage with Emma, Daya busy with Emily and Liv getting pointers from Danni. And that was all in a single pass through the training area.

Not that I really minded. This was the way it should be. The way I wanted it to be. So I hung around, just to keep an eye on them, but I was also losing touch with how their training was going. I left those concerns to Steph. If things were still going wrong, I knew she'd tell me.

It made Emma's question odd, though, because she was now spending more time with them than I was.

Turned out I misunderstood what she was asking.

"I meant the matchups," she said. "Do we know anything?"

I gave her a funny look. This question was even stranger than my original assumption.

"You know how this works. We won't know until a few hours before the event. That's the whole idea."

"I know. But I figured you knew people. Maybe you found something out."

The funny look got more pronounced. What the hell was she talking about? There was no way to find anything out because there was nothing to find. They wouldn't even run the draw until event night just to be sure no one knew in advance. On top of that, knowing beforehand would be cheating, which is not exactly Emma's style.

Was she losing her mind?

Or maybe...

"You worried about them?"

She didn't say anything, but her shoulders dropped and her face fell a little. That was all the response I needed.

"Emma, when I called you in that day, I wanted you to talk to them. Not become their momma."

I expected her to snap back at me or make a smartass comment. But, nope...

"They're good kids, Richelle," she said. "I know they weren't serious enough in the beginning and they screwed around too long. But they're putting in the work now, and they're a lot better than they were. I want them to get a chance to show it."

"No point sweating stuff we can't control," I said. "You say they're better, then they'll show it. No matter who they're matched up with."

I frowned at my own words. I was getting dangerously close to you *gotta take it as it comes*, which is what you say when you've run out of ideas for dealing with what's in front of you. It implies a lack of control that doesn't exactly suit my personality.

Meanwhile, Emma detected a bit of hypocrisy.

"So, you're not 'sweating' Danni and this tournament?"

Appropriately chastened, I just smiled and took the hit without protest.

"Fair enough," I said. "I guess it's really all the same. Danni. You. The rookies. Can we tell ourselves we did all we can?"

"I think so."

"Then we'll have to be satisfied with that, and take the rest as it comes."

Aww, goddammit.